
Trump Finally Found the One Thing That Could Cause Senate Republicans to Grow a Spine

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Question: Is a country trending in a *healthy* direction if the head of its central bank releases an SOS message about the political persecution he's suffering?

On Sunday evening, the Federal Reserve posted a [video](#) of Chairman Jay Powell speaking directly to the camera about how the Justice Department had launched a criminal investigation into the Fed. While superficially related to excessive Federal Reserve building renovation costs, Powell said, "the threat of criminal charges is a consequence of the Federal Reserve setting interest rates based on our best assessment of what will serve the public, rather than following the preferences of the president." The administration is trying to spook Powell into cutting rates deeper and, if he doesn't, ginning up cause to fire him.

You don't want a central bank that makes interest rate decisions according to presidential demands. There's significant [overlap](#) between countries whose leaders meddle in their central banks' decisions and those that suffer hyperinflation. This is one of those bright red lines separating functioning countries—however barely, in the case of the good ol' U.S.—from the rest, and why the move against Powell has former Treasury secretaries and Fed chairs rushing to start a [Substack to condemn it](#).

In a political system with a functioning brain, the threat of criminal charges against a technocrat for not juicing the economy to the president's liking would be enough to open an impeachment inquiry. In the United States political system circa 2025, we'll get a handful of statements from Republicans offering meaningful pushback. Fortunately, one of those Republicans has real power in this situation.

"If there were any remaining doubt whether advisers within the Trump Administration are actively pushing to end the independence of the Federal Reserve, there should now be none," North Carolina Sen. Thom Tillis said in a [statement Sunday night](#). "It is now the independence and credibility of the Department of Justice that are in question. I will oppose the confirmation of any nominee for the Fed—including the upcoming Fed Chair vacancy—until this legal matter is fully resolved."

This is more than your usual meaningless Senate threat. What he's saying, in short, is that unless Trump's Justice Department drops this stick-up against Powell, he's not going to get the Fed chair of his dreams wants when Powell's term as chair ends in May.

Tillis' position is important for two reasons.

First, he's retiring at the end of the year, which gives him the political space to behave like an adult. Had he chosen to run again in 2026 and was facing down a primary from his right, he may well have been in Powell's driveway last night trying to make a citizen's arrest.

Second, Tillis serves as a pivotal vote on the Banking Committee, which considers Fed nominees. The committee is comprised of 13 Republicans and 11 Democrats. If Tillis joined all Democrats in

opposing a Fed nominee, the committee would be deadlocked and the nomination unable to advance out of committee. And while the full Senate could try to force a nomination out of committee, a vote to do so would be [subject to the filibuster](#)—meaning it would need Democratic votes to get to 60. Powell, meanwhile, could stay on the Fed: While his tenure as chairman expires in May, his term on the board lasts until 2028.

Then, there's always the chance that Senate Republicans could go "nuclear"—meaning, to set a new precedent, by simple majority vote, eliminating the filibuster on votes to force nominees out of committee. There are 53 Republican senators, so Tillis' vote wouldn't be needed.

But are we to believe that Tillis, while being one of the few to express such outrage, is the only Senate Republican who feels so strongly about preserving Fed independence? Of course not. His retirement, though, allows him to do the dirty work and absorb whatever expressions of disappointment from Trump are coming his way. He has the political breathing room, and the right committee assignment, to constrain one of Trump's very worst ideas on behalf of others who are, privately, terrified about Trump's move against the Fed.

And if you're trying to measure how convincing Tillis' statement was, well, consider the markets: The day after the Federal Reserve chair, who manages monetary policy for the country that mints the world's reserve currency, released a hostage video, the S&P 500 was still somehow up 11 points at close on Monday.

Even with this effective pushback, though, what's frightening is how precarious it all is. What if Tillis were running again? What if he weren't on the Banking Committee? Who, then, would stand up?

Don't let the markets think too much about that.

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